grandparents on the road near the signal. His father is a marginal farmer in Ahmednagar.

Bhatu Sawant, the CEO of Samartha Bharat Vyaspith, says the idea of the signal school took shape when he worked as a reporter with a Marathi daily in 2016. At a press conference on the Thane Municipal Corporation's (TMC) education budget, he came across a line that said the civic body wanted to mainstream children who were out of the educational system. "So, we decided to conduct a survey of children at signals and understand who their parents were, their means of livelihood and if they were in school," he adds.

The moment of epiphany came when they realised the kids could not be admitted to "mainstream" schools as this meant a loss of income for their parents. "Hence, we thought, why not take the school to them?" says Sawant. Thus came up the 'signal shala' in a container under the flyover at the Teen Haat Naka. The location was strategic—22 roads converge at the junction, making it one of the busiest in the state. The substantial idling time for vehicles means the road has a significant number of pavement dwellers who hawk their wares to motorists.

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"I sold flowers, gajras, caps etc... Now, I want to complete my education and learn trades like making toys and mobile phones"

— SHYAM RAMESH PAWAR, Class VI

Getting the children to school was tough, but the volunteers and teachers prevailed on their parents. "Most of the students are from the Pardhi community and speak their own dialect. The teachers had to learn the dialect and teach their wards using this vernacular idiom," says Sawant.

So far, seven students have cleared Class 10. When two students first completed their matriculation in 2018, it inspired more students to enrol. Of these two, one has completed a diploma in electrical engineering and is working with a consumer goods company. The other is completing his bachelor's degree in Arts and is preparing for the police recruitment drive. Other matriculates include a diploma in automobile engineering and a fitter with an engineering major.

Today, the school has 40 students from the playgroup to Class 10. Staffed by seven teachers, it has computer, science and robotics labs. Two students have been selected in an inter-school science competition to visit the Indian Space Research Organisation early next year. Students are also taught trades like plumbing, carpentry and painting from Class 7.

However, Sawant believes they still have a long way to go, especially when it comes to girls who are forced to drop out and married off early by their parents because they find it difficult to ensure their safety on the streets. ■

Mad about Children

***Happiness delivery:** Founded by Jithin Nedumala when he was just 20, Make a Difference has helped hundreds of orphaned children break free of the cycle of poverty*

By **SONALI ACHARJEE**

MAKE A DIFFERENCE (MAD)
FOUNDED: 2006
Kochi, Kerala

In 2010, when Michelle Obama visited India, she was seen playing hopscotch and dancing to *Rang De Basanti* with a few orphaned children in Mumbai. The children were with the Mumbai chapter of Make a Difference (MAD), one of the largest youth-volunteer networks in India for orphaned children. That one meeting with Obama propelled MAD to nationwide popularity.

For Jithin Nedumala, who founded MAD in 2006 when he was just 20 years old, volunteering with children was a coincidence. After losing a close friend at the age of 19, he began volunteering at an orphanage in Kochi to "escape his own pain". There, focusing on someone else's struggles helped him find deeper happiness. "I was able to focus on something larger than myself for the first time," he adds. However, he soon realised that most children he was working with, owing to their circumstances,

ASHISH K VINCENT



A FRESH APPROACH Jithin Nedumala with youth volunteers at the MAD centre in Kochi